# THE MEMORY–KEEPERS

‘Write down whatever you know of the doings of (Babur) and (Humayun)’. This ordinary phrase sounded innocuous enough and gave no indication of the seismic rumble it actually was. In 1587, having decided to commission a history of his reign, Akbar sent for his beloved aunt, Gulbadan, and asked her to contribute to this history by writing down all her memories of her father and brother. Akbar summoned other memory-keepers too, such as Humayun’s water carrier, Jauhar Aftabchi, and an old soldier from Humayun’s army, Bayazid Bayat, amongst others. ‘His Majesty Jalal al-Din Muhammad Akbar Padshah,’ wrote Bayazid, ‘commanded that any servants of court who had a taste for history should write.’ Akbar had decided, now that he had been Padshah for more than thirty years, it was time to create a history of his rule, his lineage, and his achievements that would reflect in all its splendour a life and destiny sparked by the divine. It was Abu’l Fazl who was entrusted with this monumental task, one which would take a decade to complete, and would involve an army of compilers and assistants across the empire. The accounts of the memory-keepers were intended as source material for Abu’l Fazl to use in his remarkable work of history and it was but a fortuitous accident that Gulbadan then produced a unique and precious work— the first and only record of life in the Mughal harem through the eyes of a Mughal woman.

Gulbadan was sixty-five years old when she began writing her memoir, and had already lived through the reigns of two previous Padshahs—Babur and Humayun. With the philosophical distancing that age and time afforded her, with her own lived experience as a cherished and beloved member of Akbar’s court, and due to a complete absence of any such previous recording to model her writing on, Gulbadan wrote an account that was unlike any other work produced on the subject of Mughal history. Most accounts of kings and empires focused overwhelmingly on the personalities of the emperors and their eminent amirs, as well as the battles, conquests, and territorial expansions that visibly reflected the emperor’s power. In Gulbadan’s account we see these same emperors, but they are backlit by the familial and the domestic, their edges are scuffed by the elucidation of